

Interconnection Structures

Condensed Study Notes

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Introduction to Computer Architecture and Organization

Computer architecture is the design of a computer system, focusing on how components interact to execute instructions and perform tasks.

Key concepts:

- **Instruction Set Architecture (ISA):** Defines the instructions the CPU understands and executes – crucial for program execution.
- **Stages of Processing:** CPU operates in distinct stages – Fetch, Decode, Execute, Memory Access, and Writeback.
- **ALU (Arithmetic Logic Unit):** Performs arithmetic and logical operations.
- **Registers:** Small, fast storage locations within the CPU.
- **Memory Hierarchy:** A system of memory levels – registers, cache, main memory, and storage – designed for efficient data access.

This section introduces the foundational principles of how a computer works, starting with the basic unit – the CPU, and its role in executing instructions.

Interconnection Structures:

Interconnection is how components communicate within a computer system.

Register Transfer Notation (RTL): RTL defines how instructions are interpreted, assigning values to registers.

Instruction Types:

- **CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing):** Complex instructions handle multiple operations in one.
- **RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing):** Simple, streamlined instructions for easier decoding.

Bus Structures:

- **Single Bus:** A single pathway for data transfer; can be a bottleneck.
- **Multiple Bus:** Multiple pathways allowing for increased throughput, but increased complexity in control.

Interconnection Structures

Interconnection structures are the pathways through which computers exchange data and instructions. They're essential for seamless system operation.

Definition: These pathways are the design of how modules – processor, memory, and I/O – interact with each other.

Key Aspects:

- **Purpose:** To enable communication between these modules to perform tasks efficiently.
- **Design Dependence:** The structure depends entirely on the specific data and instructions being exchanged. Different architectures prioritize different routes, impacting performance.

Basic Architecture Types:

- **CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing):** These architectures have a large and varied set of instructions. The design of the interconnection structure is critical to efficient instruction execution.
- **RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing):** These architectures use simpler, faster instructions. The interconnection structure is designed to handle these instructions efficiently.

Impact: The choice of architecture dictates the type of interconnection structure, leading to different performance characteristics and design considerations.

■ I/O Module:

The I/O module is responsible for receiving and transmitting data to and from external devices. It serves as the crucial interface between the processor and the rest of the system, enabling data exchange.

Key Functions:

- **Reads:** It receives instructions and data from memory.
- **Writes:** It writes data to memory and updates control signals.
- **Interrupts:** It handles signals from external devices.
- **Data Exchange:** It facilitates direct data transfer (DMA) with devices.
- **Port Management:** It manages multiple ports and addresses them with unique identifiers (e.g., 0, 1, M-1).

Types of Exchanges:

- **Read:** The module receives data directly from a device.
- **Write:** The module sends data to a device.
- **DMA (Direct Memory Access):** Enables fast, direct data transfer without the CPU processing each step.
- **Control Signals:** Receives and interprets control signals from external devices.

Interface Details:

Each device is assigned a unique address (e.g., 0, 1, M-1) to facilitate efficient identification and processing. Data paths for input and output are managed through the module, ensuring data integrity and proper routing.

Essentially, the I/O module provides a fundamental pathway for interacting with hardware, forming an essential component of the system's overall functionality.

■ Memory:

Memory stores data and instructions – the system's foundation.

Memory units are assigned unique addresses (0, 1, N-1), representing individual words.

Each word has a numerical value (e.g., 0, 1, N-1) to identify it.

Memory modules often contain multiple words of equal length – a typical unit.

Memory is essential for the CPU to access data and instructions for processing.

Complex Instruction Set Architecture (CISC)

CISC represents a design approach where a single instruction can perform multiple operations, unlike RISC which uses separate instructions for each operation.

Core Concept: CISC aims to simplify instruction execution by embedding complex operations within a single instruction. This allows a single instruction to accomplish multiple tasks, making hardware design more compact.

Key Differences from RISC: CISC instructions are generally more complex, often requiring more decoding stages to execute.

Characteristics: CISC architectures prioritize instruction complexity and allow for more flexible programming.

Example: A CISC instruction might perform addition, subtraction, and data movement all in a single step.

Impact on System Design: CISC designs often prioritize low-level language access and optimization of specific operations, influencing hardware priorities over absolute speed.

Instruction Set Architecture: CISC, RISC

Instruction Set Architecture (ISA) defines how the CPU interprets and executes instructions. CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing) uses numerous instructions to perform multiple tasks in a single instruction, offering potential for compact hardware but increasing complexity.

CISC: Each instruction can perform different operations, allowing for efficient code with fewer instructions.

RISC: Simpler instructions are easier to decode and execute, leading to faster overall performance, often requiring more instructions for complex tasks.

Reduced Instruction Set Architecture (RISC):

RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Architecture) focuses on designing hardware with a smaller set of well-defined instructions.

Each instruction performs a limited number of operations – typically just a load, a store, and a single arithmetic/logical operation.

This simplifies hardware design, making it easier to manufacture and potentially more energy-efficient.

RISC instruction sets prioritize speed and efficiency, often resulting in simpler hardware designs compared to CISC architectures where more complex instructions are possible.

Essentially, RISC architectures are designed to execute instructions quickly and reliably, requiring fewer hardware components.

The ‘best’ way to design a CPU has been a subject of debate:

CISC and RISC represent fundamentally different approaches to CPU design.

CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computer):

- Employs a large and complex instruction set, allowing for more complex tasks within a single instruction.
- Generally offers potential for compact hardware designs due to the ability to perform multiple operations with a single instruction.
- However, increased complexity can lead to higher instruction processing overhead.

RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computer):

- Uses a smaller, simpler instruction set, requiring more instructions to perform complex tasks.
- Promotes faster execution because each instruction is designed to be executed quickly.
- Can be more efficient in terms of hardware design and code size.

CISC and RISC represent contrasting design philosophies - CISC prioritizes functionality through complex instructions, while RISC emphasizes efficiency and speed through simpler instructions.

The choice between these approaches significantly impacts system priorities, influencing hardware design choices and potential for parallel processing.

Characteristic of RISC –

RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing) distinguishes itself through its design philosophy – it employs simpler instructions.

Simple Addressing Modes: RISC uses a limited number of addressing modes, allowing for efficient memory access.

More General-Purpose Registers: RISC architectures provide a larger set of general-purpose registers, maximizing flexibility.

Fewer Data Types: RISC instruction sets typically have fewer data types, simplifying decoding and optimization.

Shorter Instruction Lengths: Instructions are generally shorter, enabling faster processing through fewer clock cycles.

Single-Cycle Execution: Each instruction typically takes only a single clock cycle to complete execution, promoting speed.

Word-Size Instructions: Instructions are often designed to operate on single words or bytes, improving efficiency.

Simplified Instruction Decoding: The design emphasizes straightforward instruction interpretation, resulting in reduced complexity.

CISC vs. RISC: Architectural Approaches

CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing) aims to execute complex instructions with fewer cycles, while RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing) focuses on simpler, more efficient instructions for faster execution.

CISC has a larger instruction set, potentially enhancing hardware design but increasing complexity.

RISC prioritizes simple instructions, streamlining hardware, resulting in faster execution.

ARM and PowerPC are examples of RISC architectures, while CISC includes systems like Intel.

CISC designs often result in more hardware complexity, while RISC prioritizes speed and reduced complexity.

Characteristic of CISC:

CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing) architectures employ a large set of complex instructions, allowing for more flexible and potentially faster execution compared to RISC.

Here, a single instruction can perform multiple operations, enabling shorter program lengths.

Key features include:

- **Multiple addressing modes:** CISC allows for more distinct ways to access data, offering greater flexibility.
- **Larger registers:** CISC architectures typically have more general-purpose registers than RISC, storing more data directly.
- **Longer instruction sequences:** Instructions are often longer and more complex, requiring more clock cycles to complete.
- **More complex instruction decoding:** The CPU needs to understand and execute many different instruction types.
- **Instruction size:** Instructions can be larger, potentially saving hardware design complexity, but potentially increasing memory requirements.

Compared to RISC, CISC generally achieves higher performance for complex tasks due to its complex instructions.

Difference:

The core difference lies in how instructions are handled within the CPU.

Software Focus: Hardware relies heavily on software to control the CPU. The software dictates how instructions are interpreted and executed.

Hardware Focus: Hardware focuses on the physical components of the CPU – transistors, circuits – that execute instructions directly. This means hardware is more limited in the types of operations it can perform.

Registers: Registers are essential for quickly storing data and instructions needed for immediate execution, requiring fewer registers than the CPU's overall capacity. **Less Registers:** Hardware has a smaller number of registers, which is a constraint on the complexity of instructions it can handle.

Instructions: RISC instructions are simpler and more concise, requiring fewer operations per instruction. CISC instructions are complex, allowing for more operations within a single instruction.

Transistor Usage: Hardware uses transistors primarily to implement the basic logic of the CPU. Software uses transistors primarily for memory and input/output functions.

Instruction Size & Complexity: RISC instructions are typically shorter and simpler than CISC instructions.

Code Size: RISC code often results in smaller executable files, while CISC code can be larger due to the more complex instructions.

Clock Cycles: Executing instructions takes longer with CISC due to more complex instructions – each instruction requires more clock cycles to complete.

Instruction and Instruction Types

Instruction sets are the fundamental building blocks of computer programs. They dictate how the CPU understands and executes instructions.

- **Addressing Modes:** Define how the CPU accesses data and memory. Common modes include direct, indirect, and indexed addressing.
- **Operands:** Specify the data or memory locations required to perform an operation. This includes the number of operands.
- **Operation Types:** These define the kinds of calculations or manipulations the instruction supports – such as addition, subtraction, logical operations, etc.
- **Fixed vs. Variable Length:** Instructions can have a fixed number of operations, while other instructions can be more complex.

CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing) architectures use a large, complex instruction set, potentially leading to more hardware efficiency, while RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing) architectures prioritize simpler instructions for faster execution.

Word Length

Word length refers to the size of data units used by a processor. It's a fundamental design choice that impacts efficiency and performance.

- **Different Lengths:** Computers use various word lengths, typically 4-bit, 8-bit, 16-bit, 32-bit, and so on. For smaller data, instructions and addresses might be longer.
- **4-bit:** Simplest, used for low-level operations.
- **8-bit:** A common starting point for more complex designs.
- **16-bit:** Enables more sophisticated instruction sets.
- **32-bit and larger:** Increased capability for parallel processing.
- **Instruction Length:** The length of an instruction also affects word length, impacting design trade-offs.

INSTRUCTION SEQUENCING

Instruction sequencing describes the fundamental process of how a CPU executes instructions. It's a sequential, line-by-line execution of instructions, starting with the fetch of a new instruction from memory, through decoding, and finally, executing it. The core of this process involves multiple phases.

Three Address Instructions: These instructions contain a value and allow for direct storage of data in the accumulator.

Phase 1: Fetch: The processor fetches the next instruction from memory, using the Program Counter (PC) to determine the address.

Phase 2: Execute: The CPU examines the instruction's operation to determine which action needs to be performed. It's essentially a command or operation to be carried out.

Phase 3: Data Transfer: Data is transferred between registers and memory, a critical element in the operation's flow.

Arithmetic & Logic Operations: The processor performs basic operations like addition, subtraction, and comparison. These are accomplished using specific instruction types.

Instruction Types: Instruction sets are divided into four fundamental categories:

- **Data Transfer:** Transfers data between memory and processor registers.
- **Arithmetic & Logic Operations:** These operate on data, performing operations such as addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division.
- **I/O Transfers:** Transfers data to and from input/output devices.
- **Instruction Store:** Stores the calculated values in a structure called push down stack.

Straight Line Sequencing: The CPU follows a sequence of instructions – the instruction sequence, typically starting with the PC - step by step.

The PC is used to determine which instruction to execute next, ensuring instructions are executed in a sequential order. This is the basic approach used in most systems.

References

The References section details the fundamental differences between CISC and RISC architectures. CISC, prevalent in older systems, uses complex instruction sets that dictate how instructions are executed, offering potential for greater hardware efficiency but increasing complexity.

CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computing): Instructions are lengthy and complex, requiring multiple steps to perform a single operation. This design prioritizes potential performance gains by embedding all operations within a single instruction.

RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing): Instructions are simpler and require fewer steps. This simplifies hardware design and improves code execution speed, relying on faster, shorter instructions.

CISC prioritizes flexibility via a large instruction set, while RISC focuses on streamlined execution through efficient instructions.